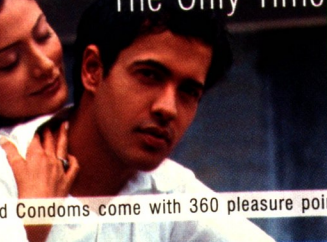




discussed in whispers. Any public debate tends to be met by hysterical outrage. In 1996, filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt commented that those who wished to watch pornography should have the right to do so. This provoked some social and women's organisations to demand his removal from the governing council of the FTII, Pune. Similarly, when the late filmmaker Vijay Anand as chairperson of the Central Board of Film Certification suggested setting up theatres for the exclusive screening of adult films, he had to pay with his resignation.

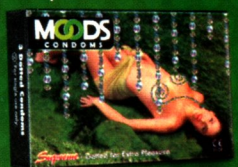
Similarly, the findings on homosexuality are likely to put the Home Ministry's arguments about Section 377 in jeopardy. The dominance of heterosexuality notwithstanding, 16 per cent of the men and 6 per cent of the women surveyed are homosexual. Moreover, 16 per cent of all men have had homosexual experiences. One out of five men and one out of 10 women "approve" of homosexuality. Twenty one per cent of all women surveyed in Ahmedabad and 17 per cent in Bangalore claim to be lesbian. Nineteen per cent of all women in Lucknow and 15 per cent in Patna admit to having lesbian fantasies. These figures provide a challenge to the affidavit submitted by the Home Ministry in the 377 case which states: "Indian society strongly disapproves of homosexuality and the disapproval is strong enough to justify it being treated as a criminal offence even where consenting adults indulge in it in private." Clearly, the Home Ministry has to catch up with the people of India. The findings will come as no surprise to those who work in the area of sex and sexuality. They have for years known that role-playing, sexual fantasies, pornography, intergenerational relationships and sex with sex workers are common.

It is said that writing and talking about sex shapes the way in which it is perceived. Meanings given to sexualities are socially organised and sustained by a variety of languages embedded in medicine, psychology, religion, moral treaties, laws, social and cultural rituals. The history of movements and language of sexuality reveal that terms of self-identification keep mutating with changing contexts. For instance, the term 'queer'



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